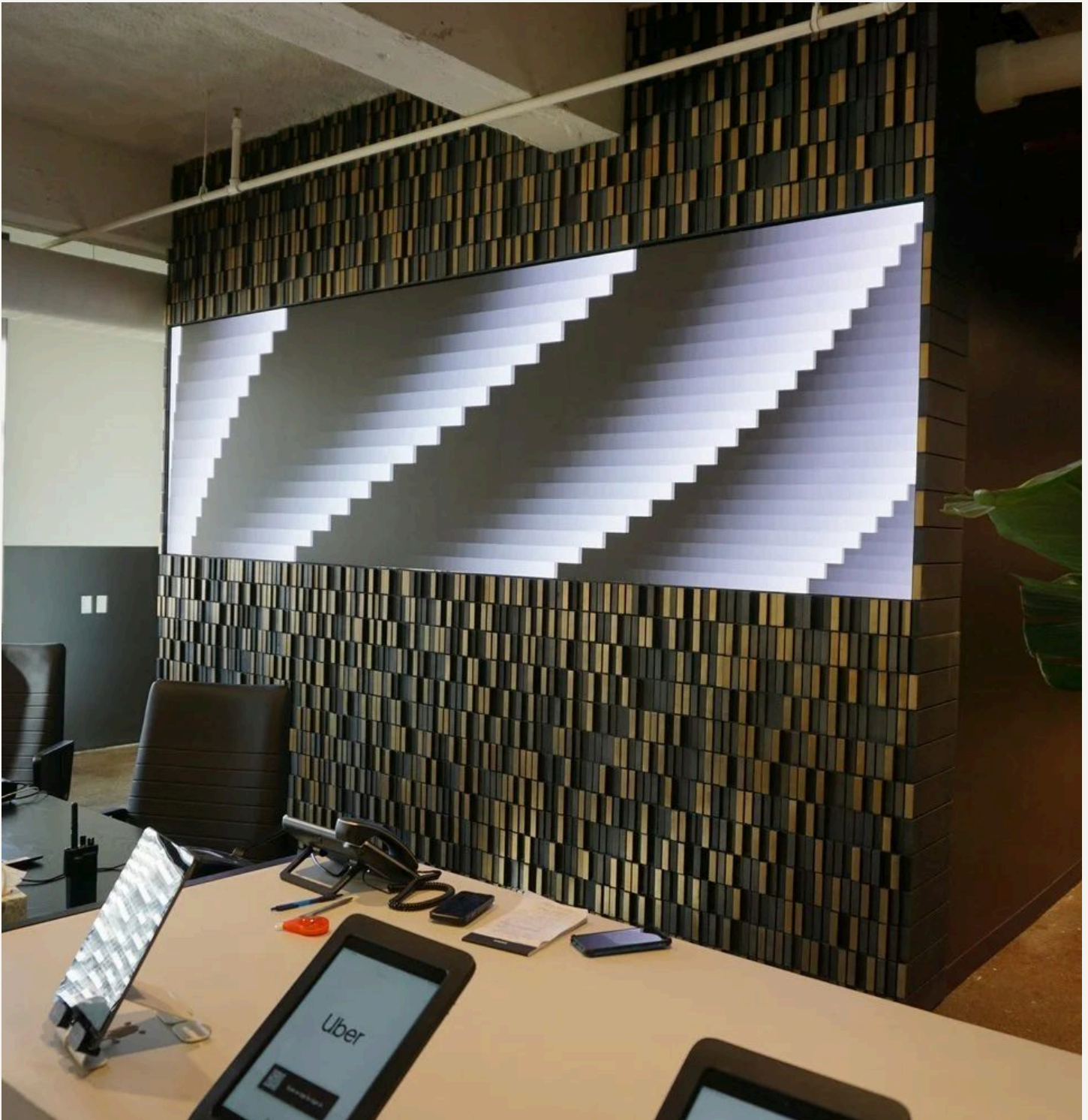


ARCHITECTURAL / 2021 / CHICAGO, IL

Parametric Feature Wall

Uber Freight HQ, Old Post Office



A cast metal wall derived from the bird's eye view of a shipping yard, modeled parametrically and cast component by component.

THE WORK

The idea came from the team at Gensler Chicago: a freight yard seen from above, containers stacked at varied heights, abstracted into a wall. It ties what Uber Freight does to the room where it does it.

THE MATERIAL QUESTION

A field of unique parts. Every panel different, all of them reading as one continuous surface, and all of them draft-free, which conventional patterns cannot give you.

THE MAKING

We built a parametric model in Grasshopper tuned to the space, sliced it into individual cast components, and printed the sand molds straight from the digital files, with no pattern in between. Done conventionally it would easily have cost four times as much and still could not have been draft-free; the design was only possible because that technology had just arrived. It was not clean. About eighteen panels came back scaled wrong: measured on site, they had shrunk in casting more than we had allowed for, and every one had to be reordered. A bummer, and a good lesson.

IN PLACE

The castings were finished and assembled on site into a single continuous surface, one of two pieces we built for the building.

DETAILS

Year

2021

Location

Chicago, IL

Category

Architectural

Materials

Cast aluminum

CREDITS

Architect: Gensler

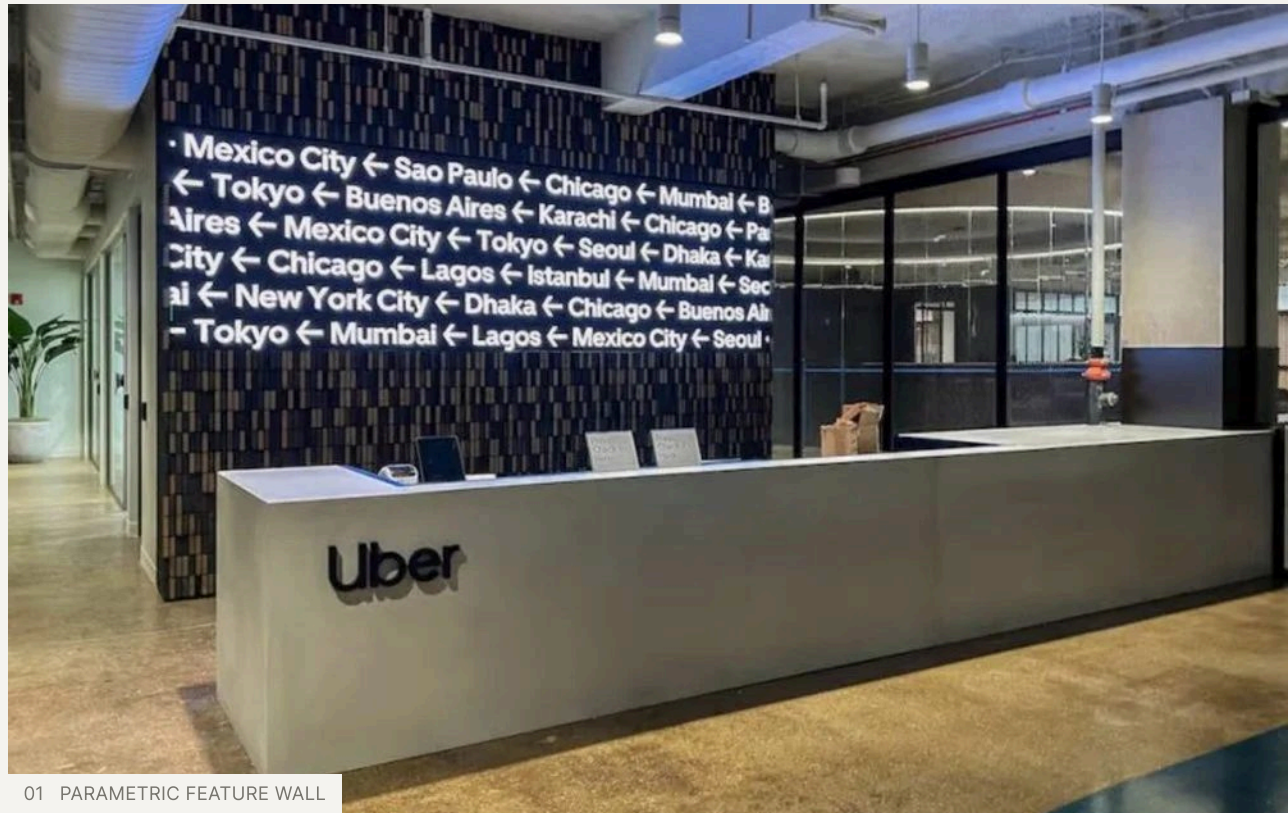
Fabrication partner: Parenti & Raffaelli

STUDIO

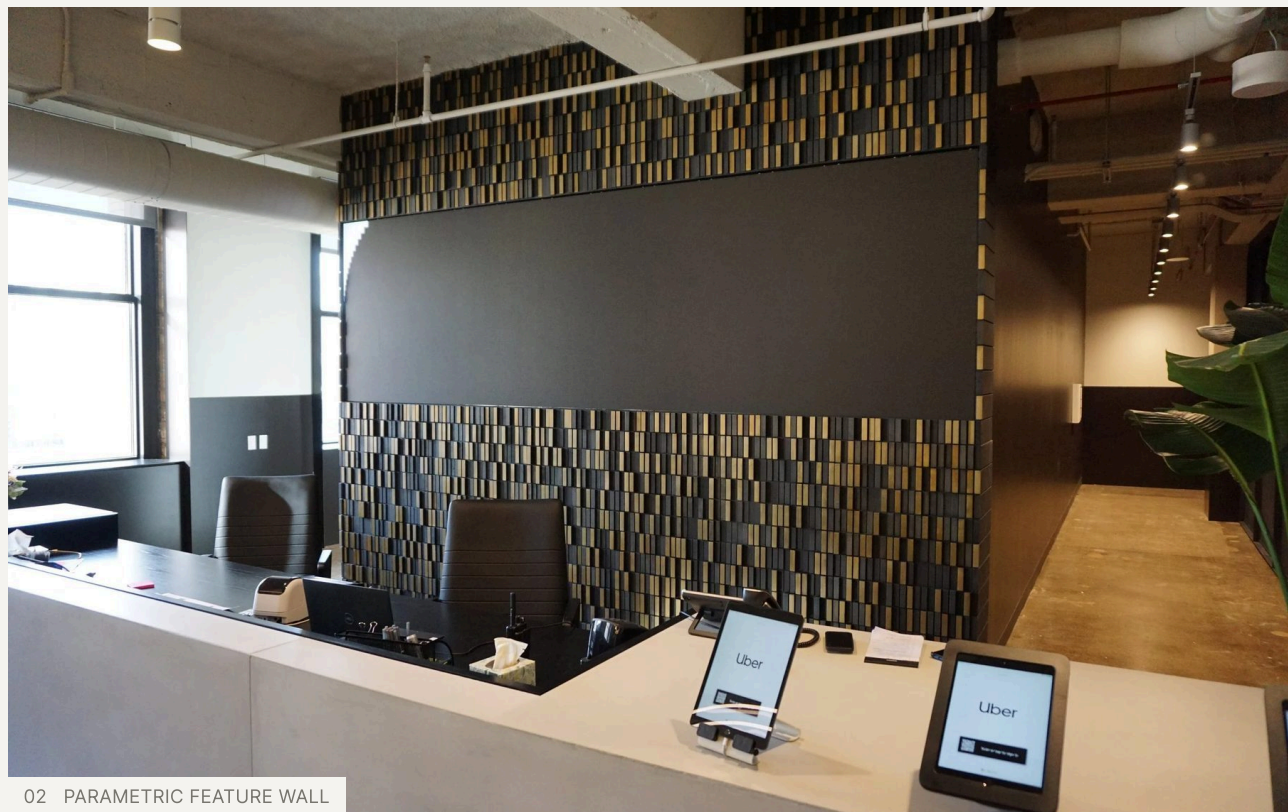
ChiLab Studio

Chicago, Illinois

Established 2013



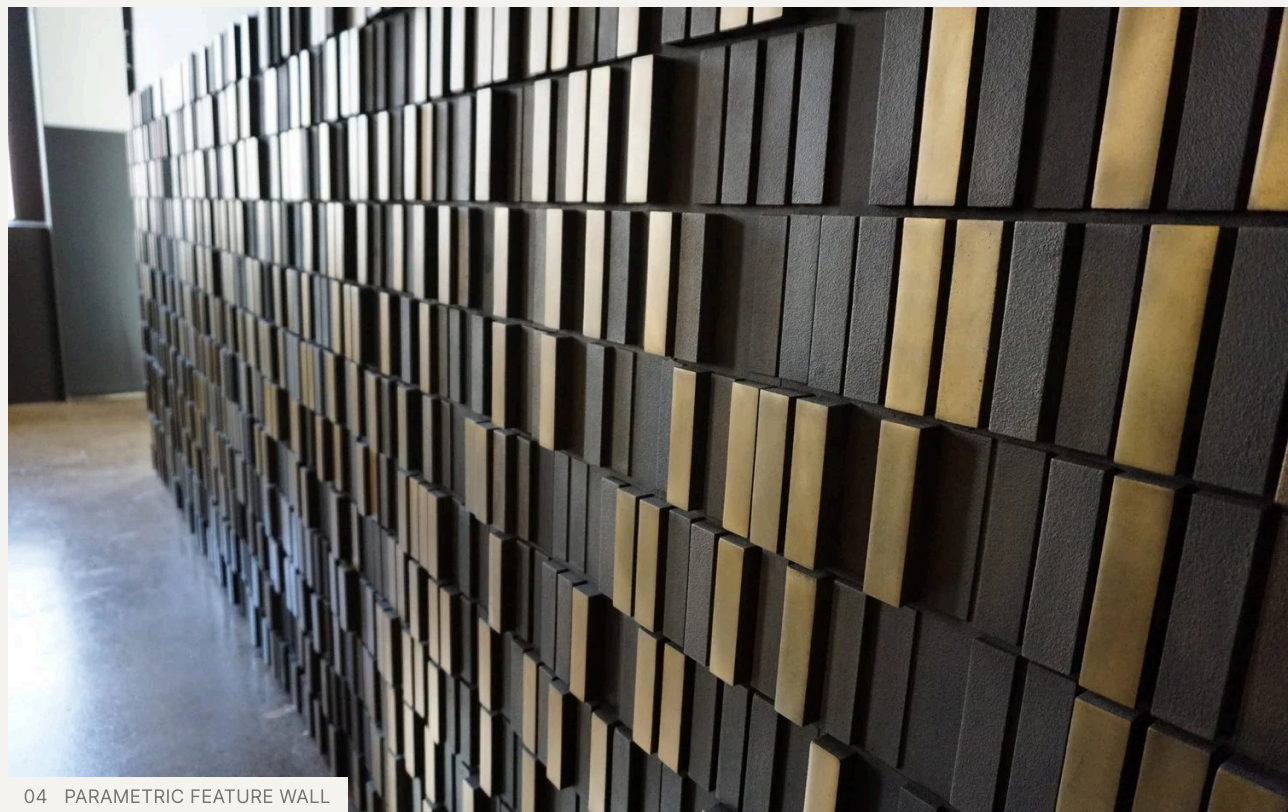
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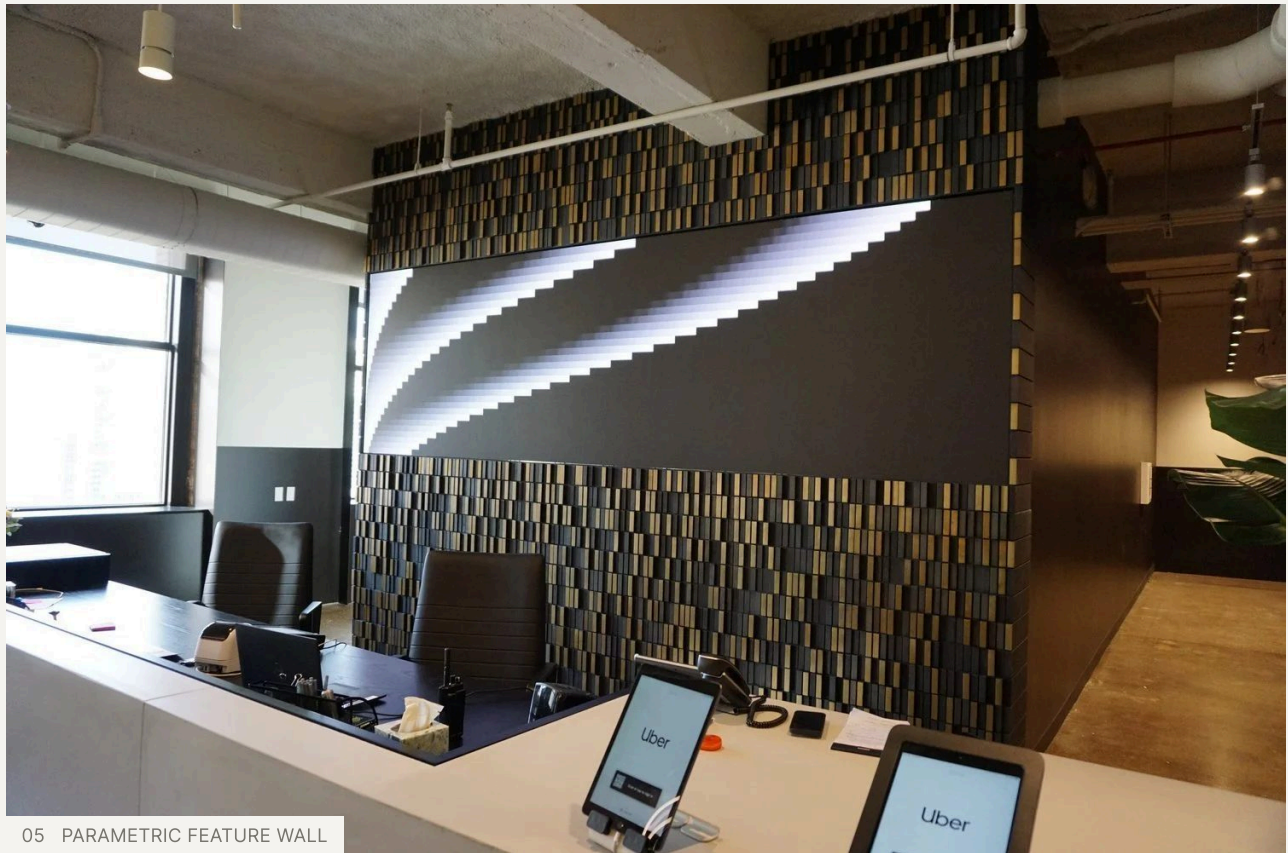
02 PARAMETRIC FEATURE WALL



03 PARAMETRIC FEATURE WALL



04 PARAMETRIC FEATURE WALL



05 PARAMETRIC FEATURE WALL

Bring us a drawing, a model, or a hunch.

THE STUDIO

Specialty material projects for architecture, interior design, public art, and the fine arts.

ChiLab Studio, Chicago, Illinois. Established 2013.

WHAT WE DO

Metal casting

Glass

Finishes

Digital fabrication

Metal fabrication

Restoration

Project management

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